

“Someday, I want to write a sefer with all of my vertlach.”

It was a casual, almost throwaway line, but it stuck in my mind from the time I was a teenager.

By then, Zeidy and I had already been learning together for years. It began when I was three years old. Every Wednesday and Thursday, Zeidy would come with My First Parsha Reader. Eventually, I graduated to The Little Medrash Says, then to Pirkei Avos, and finally to Mishnayos. We were zoche to finish Seder Moed for my bar mitzvah, and from there continued on to Seder Nezikin and Seder Taharos.

Along with all those cherished hours of learning with Zeidy came thousands of little vertlach. Some I heard once, and many I was fortunate enough to hear over and over again.

Through that learning, Zeidy gave me something that I did not fully appreciate at the time. He showed me just how rich and multifaceted Yiddishkeit and Torah could be. Torah was not limited to one particular type of learning. There was Mishnayos, there was Parsha, there was Midrash. There were gematrios from the Gra and Chassidishe stories, insights from seforim and lessons passed down from one generation to the next. There were countless styles, themes, and sources, many of which are represented in this sefer.

What always struck me was that Zeidy was excited by all of them.

It did not matter where a vort came from or what style of Torah it represented. If there was something to learn from it, Zeidy treasured it. He had an enthusiasm for Torah in all its forms, and through the way he learned with me, he passed some of that enthusiasm on to me as well.

As the years passed, I began thinking more seriously about that line I had heard as a teenager. I wanted to make sure that I would remember the lessons Zeidy had taught me. More than that, I wanted somehow to preserve the passion with which he gave them over, so that one day I could share what I had received from him with my own children and grandchildren bezras Hashem.

And so this project began.

At first, my goal was simple: “Let me just record Zeidy saying the vertlach. At least I’ll have the videos.”

So I began recording.

Eventually, I decided that the recordings themselves were not enough. I started trying to type them up, but transcribing everything word for word quickly became overwhelming. On Sukkos 2024, Chaim Weiss told me about a website called Sofer.ai, which could take the audio from the recordings and produce bilingual transcripts, recognizing both English and Hebrew. That made it possible for me to begin turning the growing collection of recordings into something written and lasting.

At first, the videos were simply shared in the family WhatsApp chat. Once I began editing the transcripts, I started sharing the written versions as well. Eventually, I realized that there should be an easy way to find an older vort without having to search through months of messages. That led to a simple website where the Divrei Torah could be collected and searched.

What began as a few videos had become a collection. And that collection eventually became this sefer.

Throughout the process, I have tried to preserve not only the content of Zeidy’s vertlach, but, to the extent that words on a page can do so, something of the way he gives them over. I hope that I have accurately recorded his words and presented them in a way with which he would be satisfied.

There are a number of people without whom this project would not have become what it is.

I am grateful to Chaim Weiss for introducing me to Sofer.ai. What might have seemed like a simple suggestion at the time made the task of transcribing years of recordings possible.

I am grateful to my brother Tzvi for encouraging me not to settle for the basic, “good enough” version of the website I had originally envisioned, but to strive to make it into something better and more worthy of the Torah it was preserving.

I am deeply grateful to my wife, Rosa, for graciously allowing and encouraging me to spend countless hours recording, transcribing, typing, reviewing, and editing this sefer. Without her patience and support, it could never have become what it is.

I am also deeply grateful to Bobbi D for sharing Zeidy with me, not only throughout all the years that we learned together, but especially for allowing him to devote so much time to the recordings and to working with me on this sefer.

And finally, I am grateful to Zeidy. I am grateful for his giving me his time, and for putting up with all my nudging, pestering, and generally being a nuisance to get these Divrei Torah recorded. When I first told him that I wanted to record a vort on the parsha every week, I said that we would try our best not to miss a week. Over the next three years, we never did. At one point, Zeidy was scheduled for rotator cuff surgery shortly before Yom Tov, when there was already a lot to record between the weekly vertlach and the additional Divrei Torah for Yom Tov. Knowing that he would likely be out of commission afterward, I kept nudging him to record more in advance. Even though he was already in pain and had plenty else to deal with, Zeidy patiently went along with me and made the time to record everything that needed to be done.

I am also incredibly grateful for the hundreds of hours he spent sitting with me, reviewing, correcting, and editing the final sefer together.

But more than anything, I am grateful for all the years of learning, for the thousands of vertlach, and for the enthusiasm for Torah that came along with them. I hope this sefer makes Zeidy proud.

And above all, I am grateful to HaKadosh Baruch Hu for giving me the extraordinary zechus of having such a Zeidy, for all the years we have been able to learn together, and for the opportunity to preserve some of the Torah he has given over to me.

My hope is that these vertlach will continue to be learned, repeated, and shared, and that the enthusiasm for Torah with which Zeidy gave them over will continue with his children, grandchildren, great-grandchildren, and, b’ezer Hashem, for generations to come.